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TELANGANA / CONGRESS

REBIRTH PANGS

THE CONGRESS RALLIES A FIGHTING FORCE AGAINST ITS MAIN RIVAL BRS WITH A CONSTITUENCY-WISE CAMPAIGN STRATEGY

By Amarnath K. Menon



TOUGH BATTLE
Congress leader Rahul Gandhi at a poll rally in Bhupalpally district with state PCC chief Revanth Reddy (left)

It's one thing to generate expectations of a revival after a long drought. And quite another to actually navigate such an operation from scratch—which needs much more than merely relying on the inertia of motion. That too through a battlefield marked by a dynamic flux. On October 27, when the Congress released its second list of 45 candidates for Telangana's November 30 assembly poll, taking the total to 100 out of 119 names, it gave clues to its blueprint for battle. In a departure from its norm, the Congress was priming for a constituency-by-constituency contest.

In the past, the Grand Old Party has often been able to ride its own elephant, so to speak. As a behemoth-like party with a captive vote, it had the space to be held hostage to the demands of community cohorts. With no such luxury available in a fractured polity, rather than giving in to that, it has stressed winnability as the most crucial factor in distributing tickets this time. This shift in strategy has not been without its challenges, leading to discord, with some former ministers and others defecting to the ruling Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS). But it's a gamble worth making, given the stakes.

The resurgent Congress is locked in a fierce battle not only with the two-term governing party, the BRS, steered by the formidable K. Chandrashekar Rao (KCR), but also with a rapidly rising BJP that is hoping to make it a keen triangular contest in select constituencies. And in a challenge to the unified, agglomerative political platforms of old, caste is becoming a primary factor. The Congress, which has enthusiastically backed a caste census nationally, found the issue smiting it the other way in Telangana. As the Congress put out its second list, Union home minister Amit Shah made a significant announcement at a BJP rally in Suryapet: if the saffron party seizes power, the chief minister would come from the Backward Classes (BCs). Shah's statement was a direct dig at the Congress, which is perceived to be a party dominated by the Reddys. The community had bagged 38 out of the first 100 nominations, though it accounts for barely 7 per cent of the state's total population. This was part of his party's broader national strategy to challenge the promises of the Congress-led INDIA (Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance).

Representation for the backwards is a sore point in the current political narrative as the Telugu states have never had a CM from these communities since 1947—even if unified Andhra Pradesh does have the distinction of having India's first Dalit chief minister in the 1960s. Though the backwards account for about 52 per cent of Telangana's population of 36.2 million, they do not get adequate political representation from any party. The BJP has 20 BC candidates in its first list of 52, while the Congress has only 19 in the 100 named and the BRS 22 out of 119. The saffron party now appears poised to give BC